

Chapter Three

CONTEXT MATTERS: A CAMPAIGN TYPOLOGY

IF VOTERS BEHAVE THE way Downs describes, comparing the positions of candidates across issues to their own positions on the same issues, then how do candidates decide which issues to stress and which to remain silent about? When candidates sit down at the table, how do they think about their campaign's message?

Political scientist Bill Riker (1996, 106) suggests candidates look for issues that are ripe for "domination" (because when one side has an advantage on an issue, the other side ignores it). This is not unlike John Petrocik's (1980) answer to this question, which is that candidates' campaign issues are made up of those issues on which the candidate is deemed more competent than the opposition.

In practice, there are a variety of answers to these questions. At American University's Campaign Management Institute, a session on "Strategy, Theme, and Message" is taught in which participants are told that the most important thing about a candidate's theme and message is that it not contradict who the candidate actually is. For example, if a candidate is twenty-seven years old and running for Congress for the first time, he would not choose a theme and message that stresses his wisdom and experience. Similarly, a candidate who likes to dress in dark pin-striped suits and wear glasses should probably not have a campaign theme centered on progressive ideas. But this is just one notion about how to generate a campaign message. When I asked Michael Dukakis (2002) how he came up with his campaign message in 1988, his answer was simple:

You don't come up with new ideas when you run for president, you've been in government for a long time and you stand for things. These are the things you believe in and the things you've worked for already. You run on those things.

My hunch is that there are as many answers to the question about generating a campaign message as there are candidates running for office and consultants looking for work. This is not a book about how candidates come up with their campaign messages. Instead, I explain the choices candidates have already made in light of the assumption that candidates want to win elections and voters want to maximize the benefits they get from government. In this chapter I answer a simple question: how might a rational candidate act, given the assumptions of the spatial model and my theory of campaign effects, in order to win an election?¹

¹I use the word "rational" in the economic sense. It refers to the way in which decision-makers

Surprisingly, the answer to this question is also simple: a rational candidate will exploit the electoral context to his or her advantage—the rational candidate pursues an efficient path to victory. The most efficient path to victory is going to be different for different candidates—as each possesses a unique set of policy positions and characteristics. When these candidate-level specifics are coupled with the nature of the times, efficient paths to election begin to take shape. One obviously efficient strategy is for a candidate to leverage his or her existing strengths. Or as Riker (1996) might have said, to engage in "heresthetics"; or using Schattschneider's language (1975), to displace and replace conflicts.² While the general theories laid out by Riker and Schattschneider are appealing, I would like to be more specific than merely suggesting that candidates leverage their strengths. In order to say anything more specific than that, however, knowledge of the actual electoral context is needed. This may seem unsatisfying to people who believe that it is akin to saying, "the right strategy depends on the times." A strategy that depends on context, however, is not one that is unpredictable. What kinds of contextual things are important to candidates as they make their plans? Very specific kinds of things.

For starters, national conditions such as economic prosperity and decline, or war and peace; and even certain characteristics of candidates can be important contextual variables. Specifically, compelling candidate characteristics are those to which a candidate is inescapably wedded. A candidate who took bribes in a prior office, one who flew to a foreign country to sign a peace treaty that bears his name, or one who comes into the political system from outside it are solidly associated with these characteristics. These events cannot be erased or reinvented the way other candidate characteristics can. For example, a candidate who states publicly that he is pro-choice is not inextricably linked to this position forever. He can change his mind somewhat reasonably. But there is nothing the first list of candidates, can do to change the noted characteristics. The first candidate, described above, who took the bribe, is not going to win an election that turns on honesty. The second candidate cannot be painted as a war-monger, and the third candidate, the outsider, can easily win an election when voters are feeling cynical about Beltway politics. This is the difference between

evaluate the alternatives they face by the relationship between the choice and the goal. Rationality refers to the decisions about the *means* of achieving a goal. A rational candidate moves toward victory in a way that, to the best of his or her knowledge, uses the least possible input of scarce resources; rational decision-makers are efficient pursuers of their goals. Rationality refers to the processes of action, not to the ends or even the success at reaching desired ends.

²Riker's term, "heresthetics," is the process of structuring a contest to leverage preexisting dimensions on which advantages are already held. Riker argued in his work on campaign strategy that candidates should not spend time trying to persuade voters that their positions are better than the opposition; nor should they converge to the median voter's position on issues. Instead, candidates should refocus the election onto a dimension on which they are already advantaged. This is similar to Schattschneider's (1975) idea of "displacement" and "conflict."

a characteristic that can matter and one that cannot. For something about a candidate to be important to the electoral context, it must be something that the candidate cannot change or manipulate easily; and obviously, it must be something about which the voters care or can be made to care.

Saying context matters is not the same as saying campaign themes have to be decided on a case-by-case basis. If we know what issues or ideas are regularly important to voters during elections (or can be made important) and how public opinion typically reacts to these issues, we can characterize campaign messages that help candidates efficiently win elections. I start with a campaign typology that is general enough to be applied to all presidential elections and apply it more specifically to actual candidates over the course of the book. Throughout the remainder of the book I use language suggesting that the theory is useful as a predictive tool, however, I examine past campaigns to highlight the explanatory power of the theory. To be clear, my interest is in explanation *and* prediction. It is not enough for this theory to generate accurate predictions about what types of campaigns candidates are likely to run and whether those campaigns will win elections. I also want to know why these predictive relationships work—thus in chapter 6 I focus on the individual-level mechanisms driving the aggregate- and candidate-level results.

THEORETICAL PREDICTIONS

My theory of campaign effects suggests three ways that candidates can increase votes: agenda setting, persuading, and clarifying. Clearly, it is much easier for a candidate to take advantage of an issue that is already important to voters than for a candidate to have to *convince* voters of an issue's importance. But in order to run this type of clarifying campaign, a candidate must be on the right side of the issue. To complicate things even more, in order to get any kind of significant increase in votes from this issue, public opinion on it should be one-sided—the more one-sided the better. This already sounds like a challenging task. Are there any issues with consistently lopsided public opinion about which voters routinely care?

According to the Gallup Organization, which has been asking people about the nation's most important problem since 1946, there are a couple of issues that are consistently on the minds of voters during election years. These include foreign policy, the economy, crime and safety, and health care. Two of these issues stand out for their prominence within years and steady presence over years: the economy and foreign policy (Smith 1985). Table 3.1 presents the percentage of Americans who named foreign policy and the economy as the nation's most important problems in the first quarter of election years since 1952.³ Foreign

TABLE 3.1
Percentage of People Believing Foreign Policy and the Economy Are Nation's Most Important Problem, 1952–2008

Poll Date	Foreign Policy	Economy	Number of Respondents
Jan. 6, 1952	4	29	1500
March 8, 1956	36	31	1559
Feb. 4, 1960	37	17	1638
March 27, 1964	38	14	1676
Jan. 4, 1968	57	15	1502
Feb. 4, 1972	32	38	1502
Jan. 2, 1976	9	71	1572
Jan. 25, 1980	48	43	1597
Feb. 10, 1984	22	38	1610
Sep. 7, 1988	9	40	1003
March 26, 1992	3	95	1004
Jan. 12, 1996	4	35	1039
March 10, 2000	4	25	1006
March 11, 2004	19	53	1005
March 9, 2008	26	55	1012

Source: The Gallup Organization.

policy is mentioned more often than the economy from 1956 to 1968, but in 1972 the tide begins to change (along with the world), and the economy becomes more of a concern to people throughout the latter part of the decade. This culminates in 1992, when nearly every person Gallup polled mentioned the economy as the nation's most important problem. Foreign policy and the economy are good possibilities for issues on which candidates can leverage their popularity.

There is, however, something special about the economy as a campaign issue. Not only do voters think about the state of the nation's economy as an important problem during election years, the weight of existing evidence showing the important role of economic conditions on electoral outcomes is extraordinary. The simplicity of the relationship between public opinion and the nation's economy also makes it attractive as a campaign issue. Public opinion on retrospective evaluations of the economy is easy to read.

³In 1988 I had to use data from later in the year as Gallup did not ask this question in the first quarter.

good, and further, opinion on this issue is incredibly one-sided—everyone prefers prosperity to decline.⁴

Foreign policy does not provide the same clarity, stability, or transparency in terms of the preferred opinion over time or the percentage split between opinions. While it is true that everyone prefers peace to war, opinion is much more divided about how to achieve or maintain peace than about how to do the same for prosperity. Consider the history of incumbency during war. Voters rarely dismiss an incumbent president during times of war, but sometimes (as for Truman and Johnson) things are going so badly that incumbents decide not to run for a second term. We rarely see cases of incumbents in good economies deciding not to run for office again. There is more stability and predictability in public opinion about the economy than there is in attitudes about foreign policy.

In the fall of 1952, the Gallup Organization asked Americans whether the United States should have sent military forces into Korea. Forty-three percent of Americans said yes and 37 percent said no (the Gallup Organization, October 17, 1952). The same divided opinion existed in the winter of 1968 when Gallup asked about the use of military force in Vietnam—42 percent thought it was a mistake and 46 percent thought it was not (the Gallup Organization, February 1, 1968). Even though this issue is important to voters during the 1968 election, a candidate who thinks he can win on this issue is mistaken, since roughly half of all Americans are on each side. What is further interesting about public opinion on war and foreign policy is that it changes as the wars change. Support for the use of force in Korea grew over the course of 1952, while support for Vietnam shrank during 1968. Candidates cannot know what is going to happen in a war, or in the world, that might change public opinion about the use of military force, making this issue a relatively risky one on which to base a clarifying campaign. A candidate could find him- or herself clarifying a position on this important foreign policy issue only to find public opinion on the issue changing in the middle of the year or campaign, along with the candidate's benefits from being on the "right side" of this issue.⁵

The way the media cover war and foreign policy in recent years also complicates the use of this as a clarifying issue. Daily or even hourly pictures from the battlefield are now the norm. The instant something happens, Americans know

⁴The reason I use retrospective evaluations of the economy here instead of economic policy is because when people report the economy as one of the nation's most important problems to Gallup, they are not referring to the president's tax policy or budget proposals, but to the state of the nation's economy or how well they are doing individually. When people do state a specific policy directly, Gallup represents it as its own category. The fact that people use general valence language when describing economic problems, however, does not mean that these retrospective evaluations implicitly lack specific policy content. They should be viewed as a proxy for the continuation (or discontinuation) of the incumbent party's economic policy, even though voters do not explicitly use this language.

⁵Unlike economic downturns, a solid case can be made for going to war (or increasing troop and spending levels), and has been made during this time period.

about it and are reacting to it. It is very difficult for candidates to predict the quantity of information to which voters will be subjected on this issue.

It is also true that the economy can change over the course of an election year; however, two things mitigate the risk associated with this issue. Primarily, changes in the economy happen gradually and progressively, barring some unusual occurrence. This gives candidates confidence that the state of the economy in the second quarter of the election year is a good predictor of the state of the economy during the summer and in to the election (or at least a good predictor of the trend). Additionally, the way voters experience the economy helps to make it a much wiser choice as a clarifying issue. The economy has an ethereal quality to it—it is housing starts, consumer confidence, unemployment, and inflation all wrapped into one experience. Most people do not have direct exposure to these things, except when things are going particularly badly, making ongoing evaluations of the economy by voters difficult. In fact, Americans mostly learn about the state of the economy when quarterly (or monthly) statistics from the Bureau of Labor Statistics or some other executive branch agency are reported on the news. Since this information is only released a few times a year and usually takes some time to compile, voters are learning in October about the state of their economy during the preceding summer months. There are no "this just in . . ." updates on the economy as there are about foreign affairs. Candidates know exactly how much information voters will have on the economy at all times during the campaign. In short, public opinion on the economy is highly weighted, its direction is easy to predict, and candidates can know whether the state of the nation's economy will benefit them or hurt them very early in the election year, when they are putting together their campaign plans. All of these factors make the economy critical to candidates' decisions about the issues and ideas on which they will campaign.

A CAMPAIGN TYPOLOGY

Clarifying Campaigns

Candidates who are helped by the state of the nation's economy should run campaigns in which they simply clarify their positions or their role in fostering the good economic times or their lack of a role in bringing about bad times.⁶ These candidates are clarifying candidates, and the economy is the clarifying issue. Since this issue is always important to voters in presidential elections, the

⁶Duch and Stevenson (2008) introduce an interesting idea into the individual-level modeling of economic voting and suggest that voters reward or punish parties in terms of economic performance by figuring out to what extent the incumbent party has control over the economic conditions. This raises an interesting role for the campaign as a set of messages aimed at helping voters extract that competency signal about the incumbent party.

candidate who benefits from the economic context need only clarify this link to win favor among voters. This is the first deduction from the theory of campaign effects and it has two corollaries: clarifying candidates should talk about the economy more than any other issue in their campaigns, because they get easy benefits from doing so, and they should talk about it more than their opponent talks about it. In the latter case, if a clarifying candidate does not dominate the discussion of the economy, his opponent may be able to convince voters that the clarifying candidate is incapable of sustaining the economic boom or digging out of the slump.⁷ The effects of this type of campaign among voters ought to be observed as a decrease in the uncertainty measure associated with economic evaluations as voters become more certain that things are “good” or “bad” (and that the incumbent party is linked to that condition) depending on what the clarifying candidate is telling them.⁸

Insurgent Campaigns

Candidates who will not be helped by the state of the nation's economy have to find something else to talk about in their campaigns. Quite naturally, these candidates ought to try to refocus the election off the economy and onto an issue from which they can benefit. These types of candidates are insurgent candidates and the issues on which they run are called insurgent issues.⁹ It is the insurgent candidate who is engaging in Riker's classic heresthetic effort. These candidates try to leverage current conditions and opinions on issues in a way that will benefit them to the detriment of their opponents. In Riker's work on political manipulation, the act of heresthetics always seems effortless (beyond

⁷The clarifying candidate's opponent may also want to talk about the economy to claim that he or she, too, can continue the prosperity, but economic evaluations in the Downs and Fiorina framework are made retrospectively about the incumbent party. Downs goes so far as to say explicitly that voters know what life is like under the incumbent party, therefore there is no ambiguity associated with generalizing about the future from the present. In evaluating the opposition party, even if it claims the same positions on economic issues (or the same valence signal), it is more difficult for voters to know with certainty what life under an out-party administration (given current conditions) would be like. This ambiguity makes voters less likely to believe the opposition party can deliver the same benefits that the voter *knows* the incumbent party can deliver.

⁸Alvarez (1992) finds that a reduction in uncertainty will also lead to an increase in the weight of the issue as voters weigh more heavily those issues on which they have less uncertainty. This may or may not be the case for retrospective evaluations of the economy, which are already highly important to voters on Election Day.

⁹I realize the use of the word “insurgent” to describe candidates who need to refocus the election off the economy is a nonstandard use of the word, especially since we typically think of an insurgent as someone who rebels against the government or the leadership of their party. In my usage here, think of the insurgent candidate as rebelling against the structural conditions that predetermine the contest in which he or she is about to compete. The insurgent candidate is striking out against power—the power of the economy as a structural feature of American presidential elections. He or she has to battle general political rhythms and redefine the election on new terms.

identifying the strategy). In reality, these candidates have their work cut out for them.

There are two corollaries to the theory of campaign effects that describe the insurgent campaign, and they have to do with issue choice. The choice of insurgent issue is critical. The issue must be one on which the insurgent candidate benefits from the state of public opinion more than the clarifying candidate does (and the more one-sided opinion is on this issue, the better). More important, the insurgent issue should be one on which the clarifying candidate has previously taken, or is constrained in some way by, an unpopular position or characteristic. This is vitally important. If the insurgent candidate successfully resets the electoral agenda onto this other issue from which he hopes to benefit, and then the clarifying candidate can come along and take the exact same position on this issue as the insurgent candidate, then the latter can split the votes on this issue with the insurgent candidate, and the insurgent candidate will not win. If the clarifying candidate is not constrained in some way on the insurgent issue, he or she can change or restate his or her position on this issue and steal votes away from the insurgent candidate. Insurgent candidates ought to pick issues that directly exploit the weaknesses or constraints of their opponents—who should all be running on the state of the nation's economy. Among voters, the effects of the insurgent campaign will be seen as the weight of the insurgent issue gets bigger over the course of the campaign. This is the evidence that insurgent candidates have refocused the election onto this issue. They should also decrease voter's levels of uncertainty about their position on this issue as they discuss it repeatedly. Table 3.2 presents the campaign typology derived from the theory of campaign effects and the corollaries of each type of candidate behavior.

It is worth noting at this point that campaign types are determined *before* elections begin by the state of the economy *not* by the behavior of candidates once they start to campaign. For example, a candidate who tries to reset the electoral agenda onto the issue of global warming is not the insurgent candidate just because he or she is trying to reset the agenda. Similarly, a candidate who talks mainly about the War on Terrorism is not a clarifying candidate because he is clarifying his position on an important issue in this election. The behavior of candidates in campaigns does not predict the type of campaign a rational candidate should run, the objective state of the nation's macroeconomy determines candidates' campaign types. Their behavior in campaigns is data with which evaluations can be made about whether they ran the type of campaign the theory predicts.

When the Economy Is Mixed

In an ideal setting, there would be one clarifying candidate and one insurgent candidate in every presidential election. The candidates may not behave this way, but the campaign typology describes mutually exclusive

TABLE 3.2
A Campaign Typology: Clarifying and Insurgent Campaigns

Economy Helps Candidate Incumbent party in good economy or challenging party in bad economy.	Economy Does Not Help Candidate Incumbent party in bad economy or challenging party in good economy.
Clarifying Campaign Talk about economy more than anything else in the campaign to reduce voters' uncertainty about your relationship to current economic situation.	Insurgent Campaign Choose an issue on which insurgent candidate benefits from public opinion more than clarifying candidate (the more lopsided the distribution of opinion, the better).
Talk about the economy more than the insurgent candidate to prevent him or her from increasing voters' uncertainty about your relationship to current economic situation.	Must be an issue on which clarifying candidate is committed to or constrained by previously taken unpopular position.
Individual-Level Effects Decreasing uncertainty about retrospec- tive economic evaluations over course of campaign.	Individual-Level Effects Increasing weight of insurgent issue over course of the campaign.
Possible increase in weight of retrospec- tive economic evaluations.	Decreasing uncertainty about insurgent candidate's placement on insurgent issue.

paings with distinct and specific candidate behavior associated with each type. Since the initial step in deciding to run a clarifying campaign is whether a candidate benefits from the state of the nation's economy, it stands to reason that only one candidate can be in this category during a presidential general-election campaign. Since the other candidate does not benefit from the economy, he or she must focus on something else. This simple rule may not work so well once we take the theory out into the real world, where, sometimes, the state of the nation's economy is stagnant—not necessarily growing, but not in decline either.

How many elections in the last half century have been conducted during times of a mixed economy? Not many. In fact, evaluating Hibbs's (2000) model, which uses economic data (real disposable income per capita) from every part of a president's term in office except the first quarter, only three elections are held during times when the economy is not clearly helping one candidate.¹⁰ Even so, when the economy is teetering on the edge of decline, what is a candi-

¹⁰I generated predicted values using two-party vote shares and Hibbs's average change in RDI over the course of each incumbent's tenure in office, used the predicted values to generate z-scores, and calculated probabilities of winning for each incumbent party. Only 1976, 1996, and 2000 generated predictions between 40 and 70 percent. The rest were decidedly high or low.

date to do? Should a clarifying candidate talk about a marginally decent economy that might just turn bad any day? Should an insurgent candidate ignore this economy?

In these situations there are two things that can happen. Both candidates can behave like insurgent candidates, and try to refocus the election off of the economy and onto something else that benefits their fortunes. The insurgent candidate would be doing this anyway, so this scenario only entails a shift by the clarifying candidate, away from talking about the marginally good economy and toward some other issue that he or she feels will bring more voters to the polls.

The other possible scenario is that both candidates talk about the economy, both behaving as if they were clarifying candidates. In this case, the out-party-insurgent candidate decides that the economic situation (small increase in growth) is so fragile that he or she can persuade voters the clarifying candidate's stewardship has not been well handled, or in the opposite situation (a slight decline in growth), the incumbent-insurgent candidate argues that things are not as bad as the clarifying candidate says they are.

The campaign theory laid out here assumes only one candidate can benefit from the economy and this one candidate should capitalize on that. In reality, these strict assumptions can be relaxed to accommodate situations in which it may not be clear which way the economy is going to go by election day.

PREDICTING CAMPAIGN TYPES, 1952–2000

Do candidates sort themselves as the typology predicts? Simply put, is there usually one presidential contender talking about the economy and one talking about something else? As a first step toward answering this question, I use economic forecasting data to predict campaign types. I use these data to make the predictions because campaign types are assigned based on incumbency and the state of the nation's economy. Because the economy is the reason these candidates are predicted to win elections, predicted winners should run clarifying campaigns and their opponents should run insurgent campaigns.

The economy has a long and successful history as a predictor of vote choice in both political science and political reality. On his War Room wall in 1992, Bill Clinton's strategists posted the sign: "It's the economy, Stupid." And indeed, by August of 1992, most American voters (60 percent) thought the economy was getting worse (ABC News/*Washington Post*, August 14, 1992), and equally as many thought the economy had gotten worse in the previous year (NBC News/*Wall Street Journal*, February 28, 1992). That so many people had cynical views of the nation's economy clearly worked to Clinton's advantage in 1992.

Political scientists have taken the individual-level connection between the economy and elections a step backwards and employed aggregate real economic data in order to forecast election winners long before the party nominees are

even known. Early work by Kramer (1971) and Tufte (1978) sparked a cottage industry in predicting elections, and subsequent work produced highly accurate forecasting models (Abramowitz 1988; Campbell and Wink 1990; Fair 1978; Hibbs 1982; Lewis-Beck and Rice 1992; Holbrook 1996, 2001; Lewis-Beck and Tien 1996, 2001; Lockerbie 1996; Norpoth 1996, 2001; Wlezien and Erikson 1996, 2001; Bartels and Zaller 2001) based on fundamental political and economic variables that could mainly be known before the political conventions were held. For example, using change in GNP between the fourth quarter of the year before the election to the second quarter of the election year, presidential approval in July, and an interaction of the change in GNP with incumbency, a simple regression model generates an accurate prediction of the outcome of thirteen out of fifteen elections since 1952 (the misses are 1960 and 1976, both extremely close elections with no incumbent candidate running).

Although they are all trying to do the same thing—predict an election winner in advance of the election—all of these models are different. Some of them include presidential popularity, some do not. Some include indicator variables for years in which wars began (1952 and 1968), some do not. Some include the length of time the incumbent party has been in office, and some do not. They vary on the kinds of economic information they use as well. Most models use a measure of growth (GDP) to capture economic performance, but others use measures of disposable income (RDI). Some models track GDP change or RDI change per capita over a year's time, and other models use a shorter time period of two or three quarters. Some of them ignore the per-capita modifier. Some use trial-heat poll results. Some account for who won their party's first primary election.

The striking thing about these forecasting models is that despite their differences they almost always generate the same predicted winner. Certainly they produce different estimates of final popular vote counts, but with the exception of a single election, 1976, all of these various forecasting models pick the same candidate as a winner, and they are correct in their estimates in all but two other cases (1960 and 1968). In table 3.3, I provide the actual two-party vote share for incumbent parties and the range of forecasting predictions for four popular forecasting models for which time-series data are available from 1952 through 2000.¹¹

Table 3.3 shows that the election forecasters, based on only a few political and economic variables, can accurately predict the outcome of modern presidential elections, whether the winner is likely to be a Democrat or Republican, or an incumbent party or out-party member. The forecasts generate mixed predictions in 1976, some predicting incumbent party wins and others not. Of the four models I have used to make this table, in 1976, two of them, Campbell's and

TABLE 3.3
Range of Economic Forecasting Predictions and Actual
Two-Party Vote Share from Four Popular Forecasting Models

<i>Year</i>	<i>Actual Incumbent Vote Share</i>	<i>Range of Predictions</i>
1952	44.6	42.5–47.5
1956	57.8	54.7–57.3
1960	49.9	50.4–52.6
1964	61.3	57.8–63.6
1968	49.6	50–51.7
1972	61.8	54.2–62.2
1976	48.9	47.7–53.7
1980	44.7	39.8–49
1984	59.2	57.2–60
1988	53.9	51.4–54.6
1992	46.5	46.2–47.1
1996	54.6	53.9–58.1
2000	50.3	52.8–60.3
2004	51.2	51.4–56.1
2008	53.4	44.3–52.7

Note: Range of forecasts includes predictions from models of Wlezien and Erikson, Campbell, Abramowitz, and Holbrook.

Holbrook's, predict an incumbent party loss while the others predict an incumbent party victory.¹² Holbrook's model is different from the others in that he uses voters' perceptions of the nation's economy instead of measures of the real economy, which may explain the difference. Campbell's model likely predicts a Carter victory due to its use of trial-heat poll data from September of the election year—perhaps too close to the actual election day not to be influenced already by people's final preferences.¹³ In 2008 only Campbell's model produces an incumbent victory.

¹²When other forecasting models not included in table 3.3 are consulted, most predict an incumbent party victory in 1976, making Holbrook and Campbell outliers (for example, see Bartels and Zaller 2000; Norpoth 1996; Lewis-Beck and Tien 1996).

¹³The September Gallup Poll had Gerald Ford's estimated vote share at 41 percent. In March Ford's share was 40 percent.

¹¹These four models are from Wlezien and Erikson, Campbell, Abramowitz, and Holbrook. Each model was used to predict the outcome of the 1996 election on October 4, 1996.

TABLE 3.4
Predicted Clarifying and Insurgent Candidates

Year	Clarifying Candidate	Insurgent Candidate
1952	<u>Eisenhower</u>	Stevenson*
1956	<u>Eisenhower*</u>	Stevenson
1960	<u>Nixon*</u>	Kennedy
1964	Johnson*	<u>Goldwater</u>
1968	Humphrey*	<u>Nixon</u>
1972	<u>Nixon*</u>	McGovern
1976	<u>Ford*</u>	Carter
1980	<u>Reagan</u>	Carter*
1984	<u>Reagan*</u>	Mondale
1988	<u>Bush*</u>	Dukakis
1992	Clinton	<u>Bush*</u>
1996	Clinton*	<u>Dole</u>
2000	Gore*	<u>Bush</u>
2004	<u>Bush*</u>	Kerry
2008	Obama	<u>McCain*</u>

Notes: Asterisk (*) denotes incumbent party.

Underline denotes Republican.

Bold denotes eventual election winner.

Even when the simplest of all forecasting models is estimated, one using only growth in real GDP per capita from the fourth quarter of the year preceding the election to the end of the second quarter of election year, the same predictions as in table 3.3 are given (with a Republican victory in 1976). The real state of the nation's economy and, in most cases, even people's perceptions of the economy do a very good job of predicting which party is going to win presidential elections, even months before the election will be held and before the candidates are known.

This information is surely not lost on candidates. The question is, do candidates who are predicted to benefit from economic conditions run clarifying campaigns about the economy? After all, holding a popular position on something that is already vitally important to voters is the surest way of increasing vote share as heresthetics, the spatial model, theories of issue ownership, or a retrospective voting model would suggest. Thus, the clarifying candidates

TABLE 3.5
Predicted Campaign Types by Electoral Success

	Clarifying	Insurgent
Won	Eisenhower (52)	Kennedy
	Eisenhower (56)	Nixon (68)
	Johnson	Carter (76)
	Nixon (72)	Bush (00)
	Reagan (80)	
	Reagan (84)	
	Bush (88)	
	Clinton (92)	
	Clinton (96)	
	Bush (04)	
Lost	Obama	
	Nixon (60)	Stevenson (52)
	Humphrey	Stevenson (56)
	Ford	Goldwater
	Gore	McGovern
		Carter (80)
		Mondale
		Dukakis
		Bush (92)
		Dole
		Kerry
		McCain

Note: Campaign type based on predictions from economic forecasting models.

should be talking about the economy more than anything else in their campaign and talking about it more than their opponent. In table 3.4, I list the theory's predictions for clarifying and insurgent candidates based on the economic forecasts in table 3.3.

Based on the economic forecasts for election years 1952–2008, eleven incumbents are predicted to run clarifying campaigns and four are not. Similarly, nine Republicans (not always also incumbents) are expected to run clarifying campaigns. There is variation among party incumbency status and type, and further, there is variation between campaign type in terms of success. Four insurgent candidates go on to win presidential elections. Although many more clarifying candidates win elections, it is clear that insurgent candidates can beat the economic favorite—and not just in times of war or foreign crisis. In table 3.5, I present a simple two-by-two table that places campaigns on two dimensions: predicted clarifying or insurgent campaign type and whether the campaign won or lost the presidential election.

As expected, most predicted election winners based on an economic forecast go on to win presidential elections, but what we do not yet know is if their campaigns had anything to do with that. As Gelman and King posited, maybe candidates have to remind voters of the objective conditions in order to cue retrospective voting, even on something like the economy. A measure of campaign content and focus is needed. That is the work of the next chapter.

PART II